



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Ascent Classical Academy of Fort Mill

School Website: <https://fortmill.ascentclassicalsc.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL**Executive Summary**

Ascent Classical Academy Fort Mill (Fort Mill, SC) demonstrates a strong classical orientation across most rubric categories. Public materials from the school emphasize virtue, wisdom, truth, beauty, the Great Books, a liberal-arts/paideia framework, a content-rich curriculum, and Socratic-style upper-school pedagogy. The campus also foregrounds a robust partnership with parents and communities, as well as a clear charter-school ethos that positions parents as partners in education. Taken together, the school aligns most closely with CLASSICAL, with Element 5 (Faculty) showing somewhat less explicit classical scaffolding in public-facing statements (i.e., less direct articulation of the “living curriculum” or a formalized teacher portrait) compared with other areas. The aggregate assessment is CLASSICAL.

Key insights:

- Evidence of transcendental/moral aims and virtue formation is visible in mission language (truth, beauty, goodness) and in explicit virtue curricula (Seven Core Virtues). Positive signals strongly align with Element 1 and Element 2.
- Curriculum signals emphasize Great Books, liberal arts, grammar/logic/rhetoric, and a content-rich approach, with explicit Great-Books and Western-civilization framing; this tracks solidly with Element 3.
- Pedagogy includes Socratic/seminar-style elements and rhetoric, with explicit mention of upper-school discussion formats and public defense (Senior Thesis), reinforcing Element 4.
- Parental partnerships and a charter model are clearly present, supporting Element 6 as CLASSICAL.
- Element 5 (Faculty) is the primary area where the site offers strong signals but less explicit vocabulary about the “living curriculum” or a formal teacher portrait, yielding a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL reading for that category.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL
- Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL
- Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

What would move the needle

- Strengthen explicit articulation of the faculty as the “living curriculum” and provide a formal, public-facing portrait of the teacher as a central element of classical formation. This would push Element 5 from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL toward CLASSICAL.
- Consider additional explicit references to liturgical or theological practices (where appropriate to the school’s mission and legal context) to strengthen Element 1’s Grounded in Theology and Liturgical/-Communal Practices signals.
- Continue to foreground Great Books, the Seven Liberal Arts, and the Western-Civilizational canon in a way that makes the connections across disciplines even more explicit for families and applicants.

ABSTRACT

Ascent Classical Academy Fort Mill exhibits a robust CLASSICAL orientation across six rubric categories. The school explicitly emphasizes virtue, the pursuit of truth, beauty, and goodness, and a formation-centered aim that aligns with liberal education and the Great Books tradition (Categories 1 and 2). The Curriculum (Element 3) is clearly anchored in liberal arts, Great Books, and a content-rich approach, with explicit references to grammar, logic, rhetoric, and Western civilization. Pedagogy (Element 4) includes Socratic/seminar-style methods and rhetoric work, consistent with classical teaching practices. The Parents & Community dimension (Element 6) shows strong alignment with partnership with families, parent formation, and open-campus ethos. The Faculty dimension (Element 5) is the field least explicit in advertising a formal “living curriculum” portrait of teachers, resulting in a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for that category. Overall, the school is CLASSICAL, with targeted, needle-moving opportunities identified primarily in Element 5.

Note: The analysis below follows the methodology using two sources:

- The school-specific crawl vector store (public materials from Ascent Classical Academy Fort Mill’s website and communications) to identify keywords and evidence. The content cited includes mission statements, “What is a Classical Education?” pages, staff pages, “Tours & Info Meetings,” enrollment and charter information, and representative program descriptions. Citations reflect the specific file results from the Fort Mill crawl.
- The classical-school knowledge base (Six Essential Elements) to extract positive/negative keyword indicators for each category and to ground scoring. The lexicon provides explicit lists of Positive and Negative Keywords across all six categories and is the basis for the category-by-category keyword analysis.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Mission language describes education as formation in truth, beauty, and goodness, signaling transcendent moral aims.
- Public materials reference virtue and moral formation (Seven Core Virtues) and connect character formation with education.
- A staff example notes the Bible as a guiding text, signaling theological anchoring within a classical formation frame.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, Wonder, Bible (the Bible as a guiding text), moral realism.
- Negative keywords present: none clearly visible in the public materials (no explicit relativism or secular-only framing detected in the cited pages).

Why this rating

- The materials consistently foreground transcendent moral ideals (truth/beauty/goodness) and virtue formation, with some theological texture (Bible reference). This aligns with the Positive Keyword indicators for Element 1 and suggests CLASSICAL rather than NOT CLASSICAL, given the strong moral/metaphysical framing and explicit virtue work. The communal prayer-liturgical elements are not foregrounded, which keeps this in the CLASSICAL range rather than a strictly liturgical model.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Writings explicitly critique the modern emphasis on college/career readiness and instead emphasize formation, human flourishing, and virtue; “the formation of habits of mind and heart” is highlighted as central to college preparation as a byproduct, not the primary aim.
- Texts describe liberal education, telos, and the Great Conversation as central aims, with explicit mention of truth, goodness, and beauty as real and knowable.
- The school uses phrases like “formation” and “liberal arts” as the organizing purpose of education.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: formation, liberal education, telos, pursuit of the true/good/beautiful, great conversation, human flourishing.
- Negative keywords present: references to “college and career readiness” as a modern trope and, in some content, a critique of that mindset (negative signal).

Why this rating

- The public materials consistently place formation, virtue, and wisdom over vocational training and vocational metrics, which aligns with CLASSICAL. The explicit critique of utilitarian college-readiness aims further reinforces the CLASSICAL designation.
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Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school emphasizes a content-rich curriculum with Great Books and primary sources, and a training in the liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) as foundational elements.
- Multiple references to Great Books and Western civilization as anchors; use of “content-rich learning” and “the Great Conversation” are repeated motifs in public content.
- The curriculum includes a public mention of the liberal-arts progression (grammar/logic/rhetoric; Western civ; Latin/foreign languages; Core Knowledge and a literature/history-centric approach).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar/logic/rhetoric), Great Books, primary sources, Western civilization, classical canon, Latin/foreign languages, logic, rhetoric.
- Negative keywords present: limited explicit references to project-based learning dominating; public materials emphasize a traditional, content-rich approach rather than a purely project-based or social-studies-forward framing. This aligns with the lexicon’s negative project-based signal.

Why this rating

- The curriculum signals strongly align with classical-content goals: liberal arts grounding, Great Books, and a disciplinary emphasis that integrates history, literature, philosophy, and the sciences in service of a content-rich, canon-backed education.
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Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Statements around Socratic discussion, seminars, and rhetoric are present in public materials (e.g., upper-school seminars, public speeches, and Senior Thesis as a culmination).
- The school uses opportunities for students to argue, defend theses, and engage in guided discussion about weighty questions (Great Books, Homer, Shakespeare, etc.).

- The approach includes a balance of contemplative/restful elements (Scholé-like restfulness and wonder) integrated with rigorous discussion and memory work, aligning with classical pedagogy signals.
- The teaching environment emphasizes teacher-led instruction, a traditional classroom authority, and a content-rich classical approach (as opposed to purely student-directed or project-based pedagogy).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: Socratic dialogue, seminars, rhetoric, logic, philosophy, wonder, tradition, memory work (recitation/memorization signals), and capstone-style Theses.
- Negative keywords present: limited signals of experiential learning, purely project-based or student-led approaches dominating pedagogy; site content emphasizes teacher-led, text-centered, canonical instruction rather than constructivist-only methods. This aligns with the lexicon's negative signals for non-classical pedagogy.

Why this rating

- The site consistently foregrounds classical teaching methods (Socratic-style inquiry, rhetoric, structured memory work, and high-quality dialogue around Great Books). This places Element 4 solidly in CLASSICAL territory.
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Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Public materials show a roster of named faculty and leadership (Headmaster, teachers) and emphasize virtue and care in public-facing teacher stories (e.g., Meet Our Team).
- The school positions faculty as central to school leadership and student formation (evidence of strong teacher presence and governance language). Public pages highlight the faculty as key players in student formation.
- However, explicit language describing the faculty as the “living curriculum” or portraying a formal portrait of teacher standards, norms, or a clearly articulated “teacher profile” is less overt in the public-facing content. The materials rely on standard staff bios and leadership announcements rather than a formalized living-curriculum statement.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: master teachers, virtue, mentorship, teacher leadership (through Headmaster and team bios). These terms appear in staff pages and leadership announcements.
- Negative keywords present: lack of explicit public mention of “living curriculum,” “portrait of a teacher,” or “faculty as the core of the school” in the published content. The lexicon flags these as explicit signals; they are not strongly evidenced in the Fort Mill site.

Why this rating

- The presence of named faculty and leadership, plus language about virtue and mentorship, suggests classical alignment. The absence of explicit articulation around the teacher as the living curriculum or a formal faculty portrait reduces the strength of Element 5 to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL.
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Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school explicitly emphasizes partnership with families and views parents as co-educators, including invitations to parent information meetings, campus visits, and open opportunities to review curriculum.

- Public materials promote parent formation via information meetings, forums, and website content that educates parents about classical education and curriculum.
- The charter model clearly positions parents as primary decision-makers in education, with a public commitment to transparency and parent involvement.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: partnership with families, co-teachers, parent formation, open campus, parent involvement, curriculum transparency.
- Negative keywords present: none evident in the cited materials (no consumer/customer framing; rather, a collaborative home-school ethos). The lexicon would flag consumer language as a negative signal if present; it is not evident here.

Why this rating

- The Fort Mill materials strongly support a CLASSICAL classification for Element 6 through explicit parent partnership language and a public-facing openness to parent involvement.
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What Would Move the Needle

- For Element 5 (Faculty): Publicly articulate and publish a formal “portrait of a teacher” and a clear statement of the faculty as the living curriculum, with examples of how teacher practice embodies classical formation daily. This would elevate Element 5 to CLASSICAL.
 - For Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations): If desired within policy constraints, more explicit integration of theological study and liturgical/community practices could strengthen Grounded in Theology and Liturgical/Communal Practices. This would strengthen Element 1 toward CLASSICAL, though it may not be necessary depending on the school’s intended religious character.
 - For Element 2–4: The current alignment already shows strong classical signals; continued explicit articulation of the Great Conversation, core virtues, Scholé-like contemplative moments, and frequent mention of the seven core virtues in daily practice would further consolidate CLASSICAL across categories.
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Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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